

Delft School

Best known for genre paintings produced between 1650 and 1670, the Delft School was begun by two pupils of Rembrandt, painters Carel Fabritius (1622–54) and Nicolaes Maes (1634–93).

Most Delft School artists were born outside the town, but worked there for varying lengths of time, experimenting with techniques to create convincing pictorial illusions. Before 1650, genre paintings of taverns, gambling and peasants were popular in northern Europe, but the Delft School began depicting respectable, contemporary upper-middle-class households, with refined and elegantly dressed young men and women undertaking genteel activities such as letter writing and music making. This was also one of the first periods in Western art where secular love was depicted directly in paintings. Fabritius experimented with light and perspective, painting dark subjects against light-coloured, textured backgrounds. Maes painted atmospheric images, with glowing colour harmonies, and Pieter de Hooch (1629–84) created quiet, back-lit domestic scenes with few figures.



Vermeer, *The Kitchen Maid*, c.1660